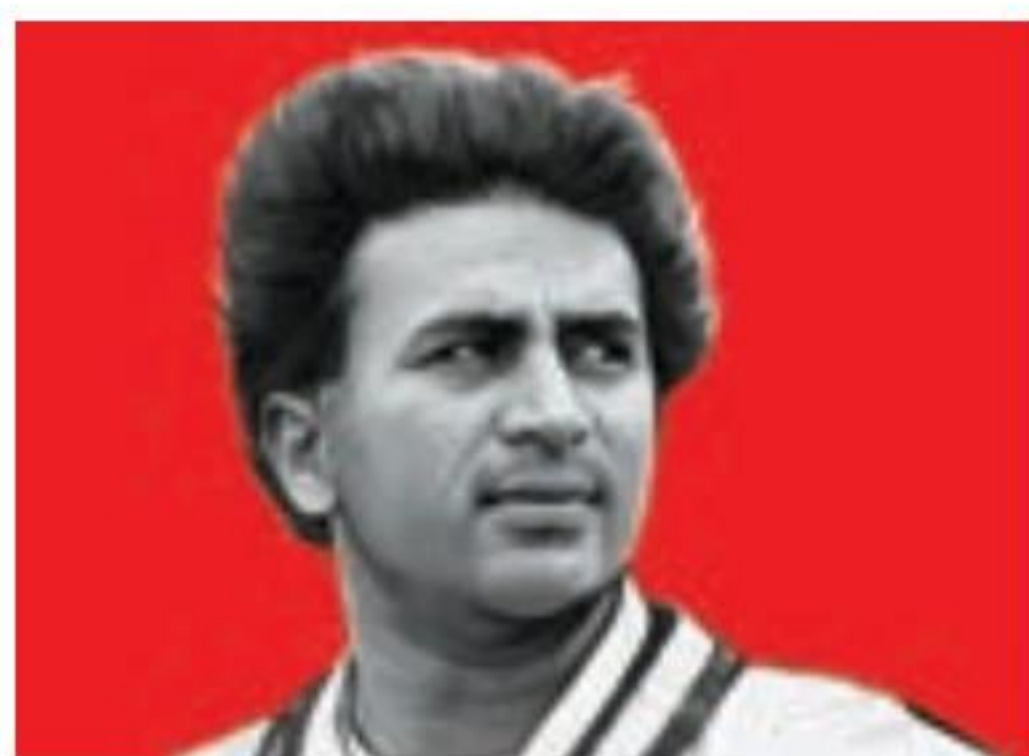




ON THE WRITE LINE

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RANJI TROPHY SHOULD NOT BE INTERRUPTED TO ACCOMMODATE A WHITE-BALL TOURNAMENT

Why is the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy not played till the quarterfinal, then a break for a few weeks, and then the semifinals and final, **as it happens** with the Ranji Trophy?

There was a saying a few decades back that 'the sun never sets on the British Empire'. When it comes to cricket, there could well be another saying: 'the season never ends for Indian cricket'. While the sun did set on the British Empire, it doesn't look like the Indian cricket season is going to end anytime soon.

The recent meeting to take stock of Indian cricket did try to come to grips with the issue. Hopefully, when the ICC meeting to discuss the international cricket calendar over the next cycle of four years from 2027 takes place, the decision-makers will realise that Indian cricketers are neither machines nor sugarcane to be endlessly squeezed for every drop of the juice.

The argument that India's bench strength is such that it can field three teams is good to make claims for the world, but the reality, as recent results have shown, is that one India team is at the moment not good enough to win much silverware. Yes, a gold in the Asian Games will once again rejuvenate the team and give it the confidence for oncoming battles, but unless domestic cricket is prioritised, the pipeline will not produce world beaters. All the best to both our boys and girls to win the gold.

One thing that is not always taken into

consideration is that the India cricket team is not Indian cricket. The India cricket team is the by-product of Indian cricket. A strong team will come from a strong domestic structure. Indian cricket is the entire ecosystem that envelops junior and senior cricket in all the formats for both men and women. If that ecosystem is strong, then the Indian team will be strong. Ignoring domestic cricket to focus on international cricket will prove counterproductive in the end. Most importantly, if red-ball cricket is neglected, then the chances of producing top-class players will reduce considerably. Look at the current Indian teams, and you will find that just about every player has come through the fire of red-ball cricket. Red-ball cricket gives a grounding that white-ball cricket hardly ever does.

This year's domestic schedule has already been announced, so not much can be done now, but the Ranji Trophy national championship needs to be given pride of place again, rather than being pushed around here and there as it has been over the past few years.

How can a tournament be interrupted to accommodate a white-ball tournament? After the league stage of the Ranji Trophy, there's a gap of over a month for the white-ball